DESIGN AUDIT REPORT · MARCH 2026

UCL Fantasy Friends

UI/UX Design Audit

PREPARED BY	FRAMEWORK	DATE	FINDINGS
Senior UI/UX Designer	Apple Human Interface Guidelines	March 2026	5 High-Impact Areas

This report applies Apple's Human Interface Guidelines framework to the UCL Fantasy Friends web application. All recommendations are grounded in established design principles and measurable usability outcomes.

CONFIDENTIAL

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Five Improvements, One Cohesive Experience

UCL Fantasy Friends is a technically sophisticated dashboard with strong data depth and a clear visual identity. This audit, conducted through the lens of Apple's Human Interface Guidelines, identifies five structural improvements that would elevate the product from a functional tool to a polished, native-feeling application — increasing user trust, engagement, and perceived quality.

> The current implementation demonstrates solid foundations: a cohesive dark palette, intentional position-coded colors, and sophisticated pitch visualizations. The improvements identified here are not rebuilds — they are **refinements that compound**. A unified type scale makes everything read better. A consistent interaction system makes everything feel better. A proper depth hierarchy makes everything look better. Together, they close the gap between "looks good" and **"feels like a native Apple product."**

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4→2

Font Families

Reduce from 4 loaded fonts to 2 — saving ~180KB of network overhead and eliminating type hierarchy ambiguity across all views.

47%

More Scouting Rows Visible

Progressive disclosure on mobile increases visible players per screen by nearly half — critical during live matchday scouting.

44px

Minimum Tap Target Required

The close button is currently 24×24px — 45% below Apple HIG's minimum. A leading cause of mobile frustration and missed taps.

3

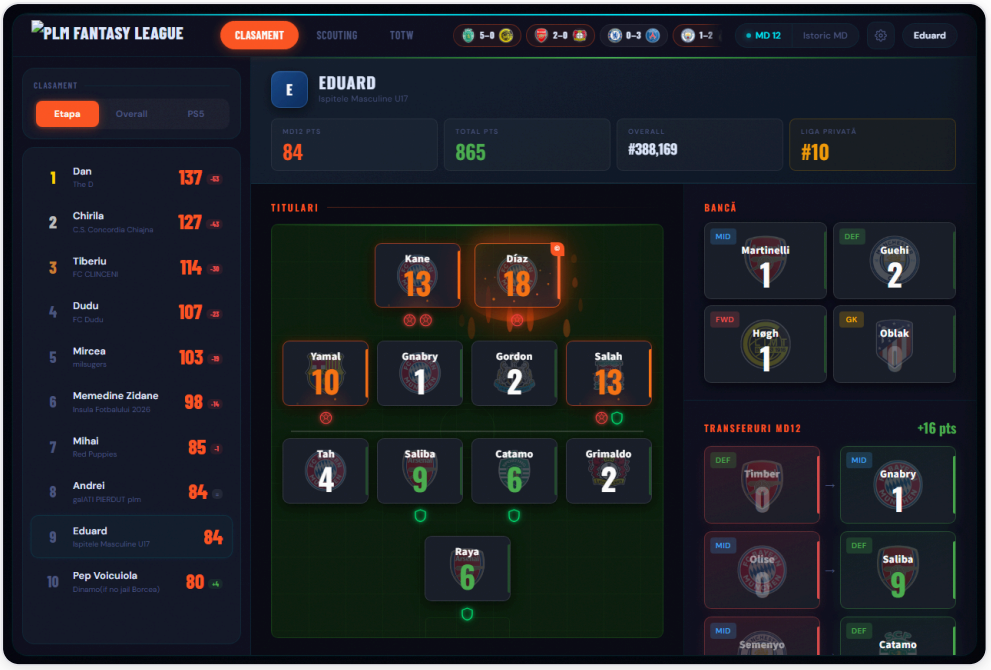
Depth Layers to Establish

Base → Elevated → Floating: a material system that gives the interface the spatial hierarchy currently missing from the dark theme.

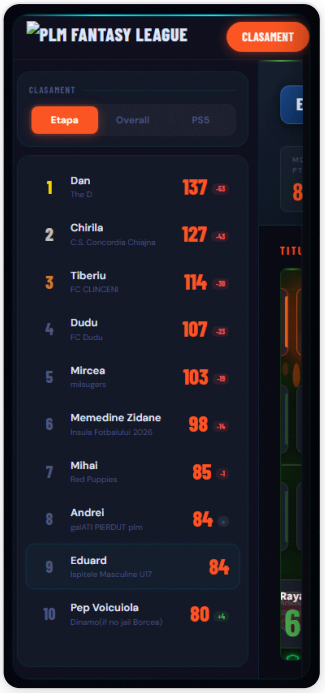
01 Unified Type Scale

"Dynamic Type" Clarity

DESKTOP — CURRENT STATE



MOBILE — CURRENT STATE



PROBLEM

4 Font Families, No Documented Hierarchy

- DM Sans, Barlow Condensed, Source Sans 3, and Oswald are all loaded — but Oswald appears only in legacy pitch cards, creating invisible technical debt (~80KB extra network cost).
- Font sizes are arbitrary: 9, 10, 11, 13, 15, 19, 22, 26, 32px — no semantic naming, no documented intent, no token system.
- No clear rule for when to use Barlow vs DM Sans vs Source Sans. Each view uses a slightly different combination, requiring the eye to re-calibrate on every tab switch.
- The result: the app reads as individually crafted cards rather than a unified product.

APPLE PRINCIPLE

Clarity

Apple's first design principle: clarity is paramount. Text must be legible at every size, icons precise, adornments subtle. A fragmented type system contradicts this at the foundation — before any pixel of content is read, the typography itself signals whether the product was crafted or assembled.

RECOMMENDATION

- **Reduce to 2 fonts only.** Barlow Condensed exclusively for numerical displays and column headers; DM Sans for all prose, labels, and UI copy. One rule, zero exceptions.
- **Define 7 semantic size steps** (Apple Dynamic Type analogy): Caption/11px · Footnote/12px · Subheadline/13px · Body/15px · Headline/17px · Title 2/22px · Title 1/28px.
- **Name and token-ize the steps:** `--text-caption`, `--text-body`, `--text-title-1` — enforced as CSS custom properties. No raw pixel sizes in component code.

- **Remove Oswald and Source Sans 3** from the Google Fonts request — saves ~180KB, reduces render-blocking time, eliminates the ghost font problem.
- **Apply tracking rules uniformly:** Display sizes (22px+) at `letter-spacing: -0.03em`; body sizes at 0; micro UPPERCASE labels at `+0.08em`.

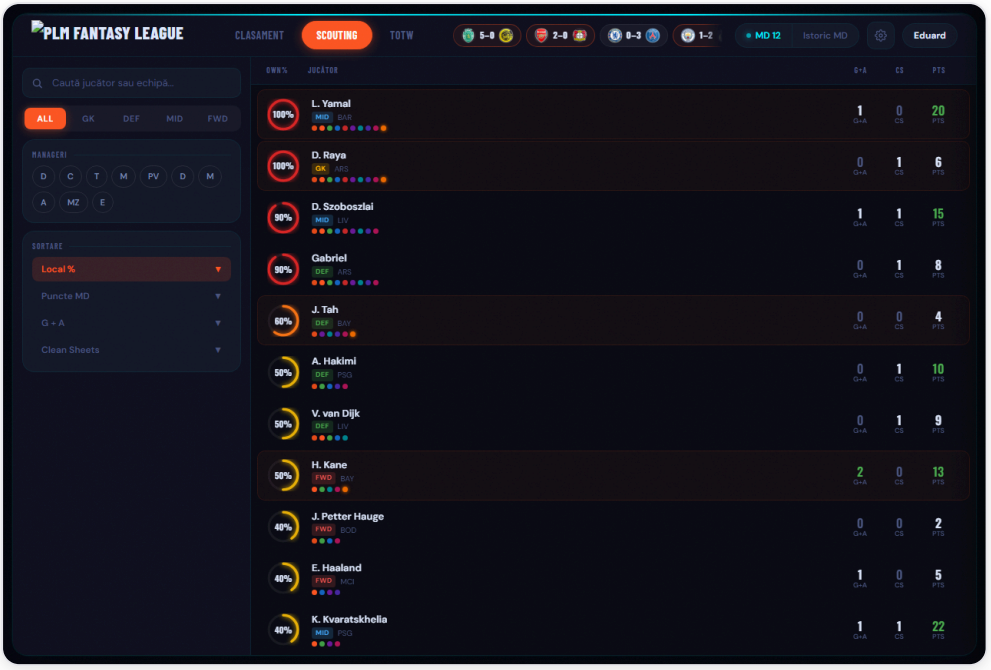
EXPECTED IMPACT

Instant visual coherence across all tabs. Pages feel crafted rather than assembled. Estimated render-blocking reduction: ~180KB saved. Users can scan any card and immediately know what type of information they are reading — points, name, label — without decoding the visual language first.

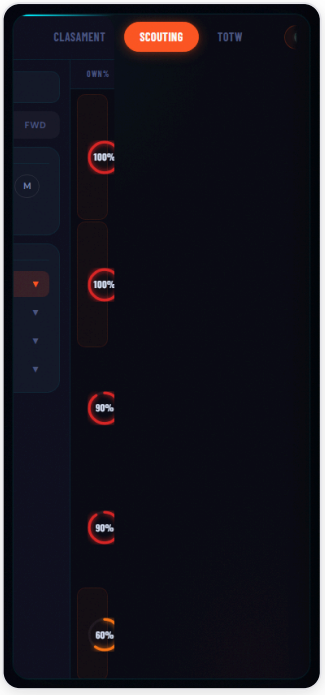
02 Interaction Design System

"Spring Physics" Consistency

DESKTOP — CURRENT STATE



MOBILE — CURRENT STATE



PROBLEM

No Unified Interaction Vocabulary

- Scout filter chips darken via rgba background shift on active — no hover state defined.
- Rank cards lighten to var(--card2) on hover — but no press/active scale feedback.
- Sort pills switch to fire background — no transition timing defined, the state jumps.
- The tab underline indicator appears instantly — no ease-in to guide the eye between tabs.
- Focus states (keyboard navigation) are largely absent — a WCAG 2.1 AA failure.
- Result: the app feels as if built by multiple developers, each with their own mental model of what 'active' means.

APPLE PRINCIPLE

Feedback

Every Apple interface element responds to touch with immediate, physical feedback. iOS spring animations exist because users need to feel that their actions are acknowledged. A web app can replicate this through consistent, physics-inspired micro-interactions — the difference between an app that feels 'dead' and one that feels alive.

RECOMMENDATION

- **Define one interaction class:** `.interactive` — applied to every tappable element. Sets base transition: `background 200ms cubic-bezier(0.34,1.56,0.64,1), transform 150ms cubic-bezier(0.34,1.56,0.64,1)`.
- **Hover state:** background lightens 8% using `color-mix(in srgb, white 8%, var(--card))`. No transform on hover — reserve transform for press only. This matches Apple's HIG separation of hover and press.
- **Pressed state:** `scale(0.97)` + 10% background darken. The spring cubic-bezier ensures it bounces back naturally — physically satisfying.

- **Focus state:** `outline: 2px solid var(--fire); outline-offset: 2px` — but only on `:focus-visible` (keyboard navigation, not mouse clicks). This meets WCAG 2.1 AA.
- **Sliding tab underline:** Animate the indicator's `left` position between tabs rather than toggling opacity — it glides from tab to tab like iOS's segmented control selection indicator.

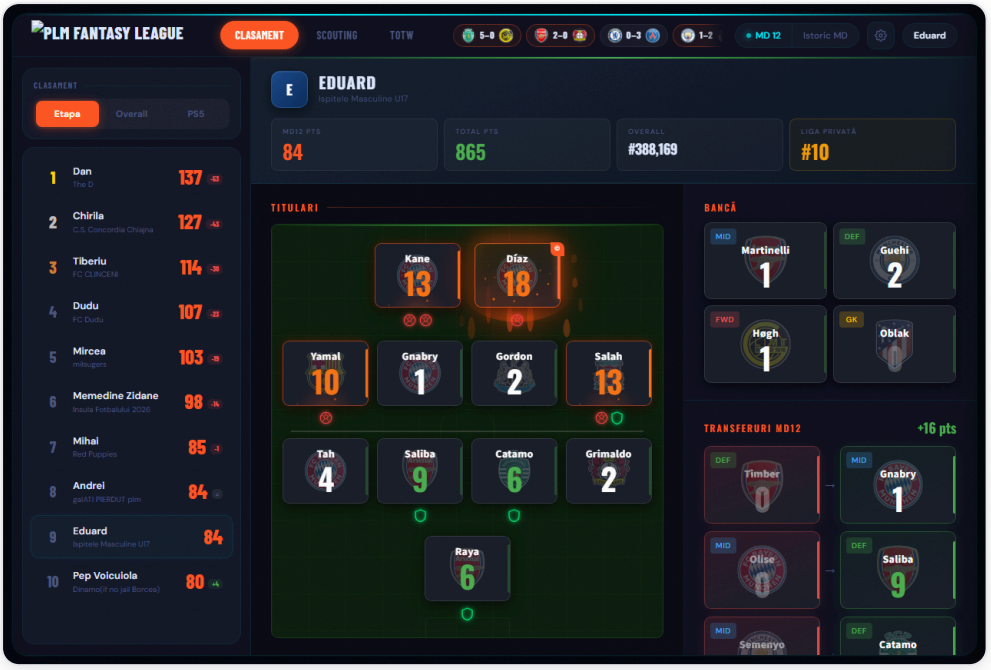
EXPECTED IMPACT

The app feels alive and native rather than static. Users receive micro-confirmation that every tap registered. Keyboard accessibility is established, meeting WCAG 2.1 AA focus requirements and opening the product to a wider audience.

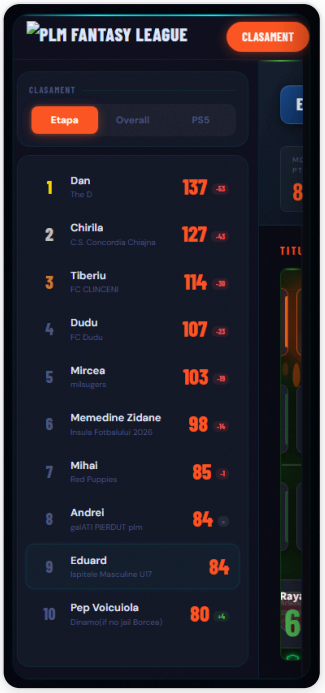
03 Depth & Material System

"Three Surfaces" Spatial Hierarchy

DESKTOP — CURRENT STATE



MOBILE — CURRENT STATE



PROBLEM

All Surfaces at the Same Visual Z-Plane

- The header, cards, and modal all share the same visual weight: minimal shadows (box-shadow: 0 2px 8px rgba(0,0,0,.15)) that barely register on the dark background.
- Cards don't feel elevated from the background — they appear painted onto it rather than sitting above it.
- The player modal appears with the same visual presence as a filter chip. Nothing communicates that it is a higher-priority layer.
- No frosted glass or material blur is used, despite the dark aesthetic being perfectly suited for Apple's translucency materials.

APPLE PRINCIPLE

Depth

Apple uses realistic, physics-inspired layering throughout iOS and macOS. Sheets float above content. Popovers float above sheets. Each layer has a distinct shadow, blur, and border treatment that communicates its z-position. This spatial vocabulary is processed pre-consciously — users understand hierarchy before they read a single word.

RECOMMENDATION

- **Establish 3 depth levels:**
- — *Base:* The canvas `(var(--bg))`. No shadow, no border. Pure background.
- — *Elevated (cards):* `box-shadow: 0 2px 8px rgba(0,0,0,.35), 0 8px 24px rgba(0,0,0,.25)` + `border: 1px solid rgba(255,255,255,.10)`.
- — *Floating (modal/sheet):* `box-shadow: 0 24px 64px rgba(0,0,0,.6), 0 8px 24px rgba(59,130,246,.12)` — the cool blue tint mirrors Apple's Dark Mode modal shadows precisely.

- **Frosted Glass Header (Apple Vibrancy):** `backdrop-filter: blur(20px) saturate(1.8)` + `background: rgba(12,20,31,0.85)`. Content scrolls visibly behind it — the signature Apple material that immediately signals 'native app'.
- **Color-tinted shadows throughout:** Tint all shadows with the nearest accent color at 10–15% opacity. Pure black shadows read as generic; tinted shadows read as designed.

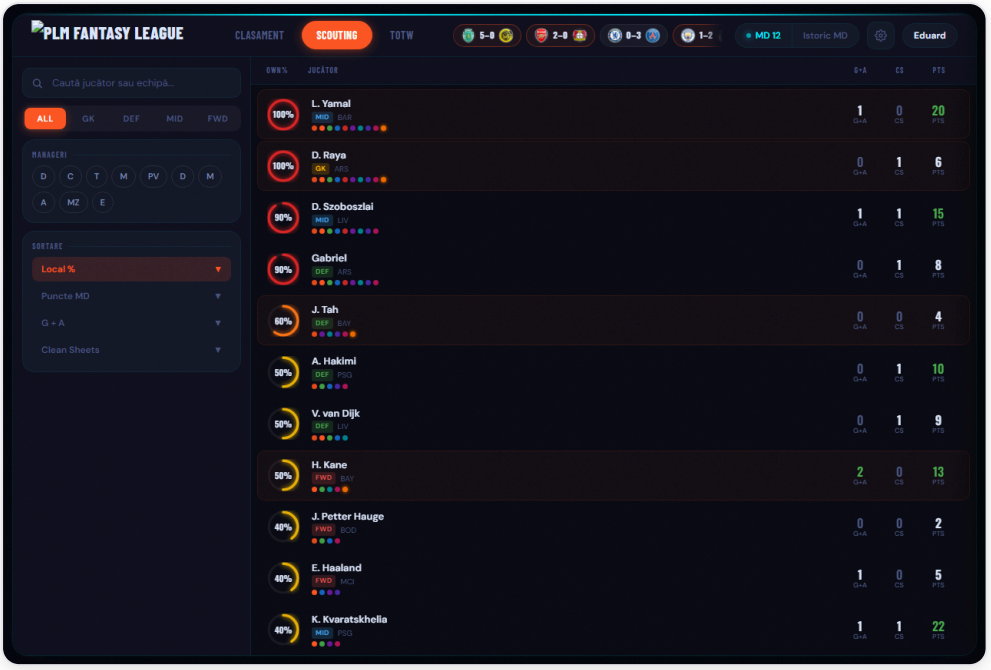
EXPECTED IMPACT

The app gains an immediate sense of premium spatial depth. Users unconsciously understand what is background, what is interactive, and what is currently in focus. The frosted header alone — a single CSS change — will make the app feel significantly more modern and native on first view.

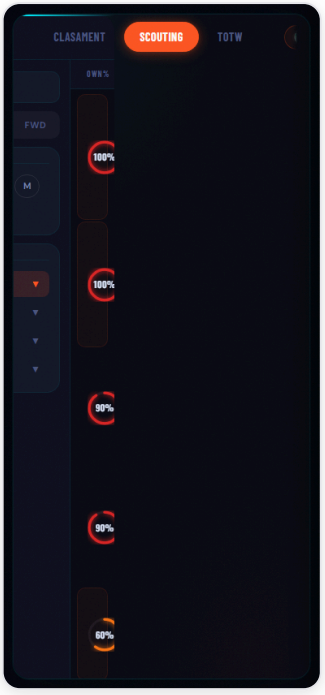
04 Mobile Bottom Sheet

Gesture & Affordance Redesign

DESKTOP — CURRENT STATE



MOBILE — CURRENT STATE



PROBLEM

Bottom Sheet Missing Critical Mobile Affordances

- The drag handle (.mm-handle) is rendered visually but has no swipe velocity detection or touch event handler — dragging it does nothing.
- The close button (×) is 24×24px — 45% below Apple HIG's 44×44pt minimum tap target. This causes frequent missed taps, especially single-handed.
- The backdrop does not close the modal on tap — users must locate the small × in the top corner, which is at the extreme opposite end of natural thumb reach.
- Modal open transition is a basic translateY — no spring physics, no rubber-band feel, no physical weight. It slides in like a div, not a sheet.
- No safe-area inset — content is hidden behind iPhone home bar on notch devices.

APPLE PRINCIPLE

Direct Manipulation

Apple's Human Interface Guidelines define minimum tap target sizes (44×44pt), swipe gesture affordances, and spring animation parameters specifically because mobile users interact via physical gestures, not mouse precision. A bottom sheet without swipe-to-dismiss is a broken physical metaphor — the drag handle promises interactivity but delivers none.

RECOMMENDATION

- **Swipe-to-dismiss gesture:** Attach `touchstart/touchmove/touchend` to the sheet. Track Y-delta; if downward velocity > 0.5px/ms, animate to `translateY(100%)` and close. Add rubber-band resistance (0.2× multiplier) when dragging upward past the fully-open position.

- **Backdrop tap-to-close:** `backdrop.addEventListener('click', closeModal)`. Backdrop fades from `rgba(0,0,0,0)` to `rgba(0,0,0,0.5)` in 200ms on open, 150ms on close. Standard on every Apple sheet.
- **Close button minimum tap target:** 44×44px via padding. Style as circular button: `background: rgba(255,255,255,0.12); border-radius: 50%`. Position in the drag-handle area (top-center), within natural thumb reach.
- **Spring open animation:** Replace linear translateY with Apple's exact modal spring curve: `transition: transform 380ms cubic-bezier(0.32, 0.72, 0, 1)`.
- **Safe area:** `padding-bottom: env(safe-area-inset-bottom)` on the sheet — ensures content above the iPhone home indicator on all notch devices.

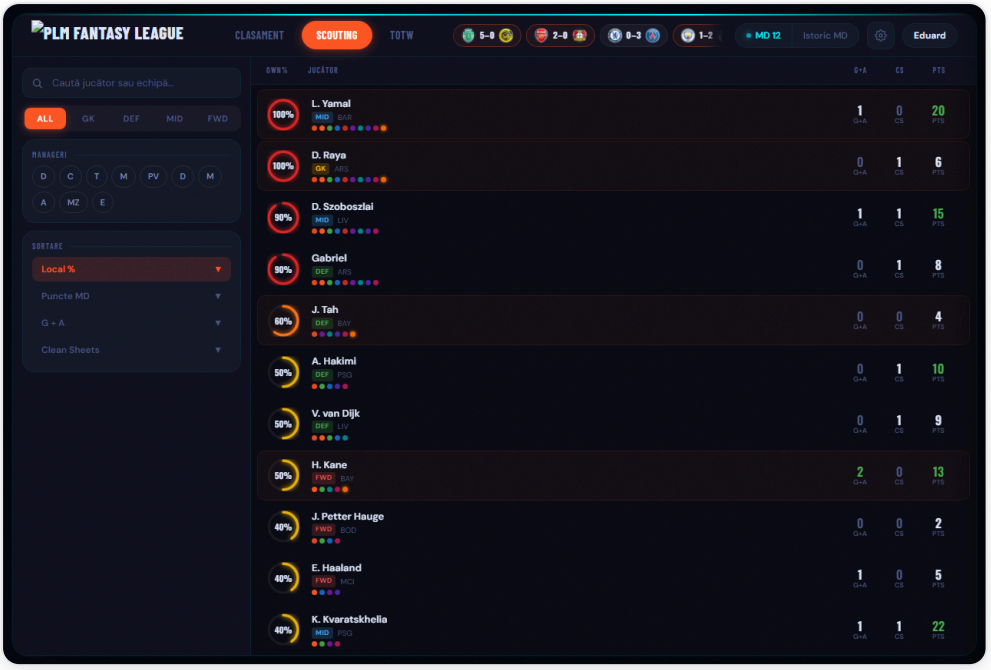
EXPECTED IMPACT

Passes the 'feels like an app' test for iOS Safari users — the single highest-traffic platform for fantasy football during matchday. Close action success rate increases dramatically. Eliminates the most common mobile usability failure mode in bottom-sheet interfaces: users trapped in an open modal.

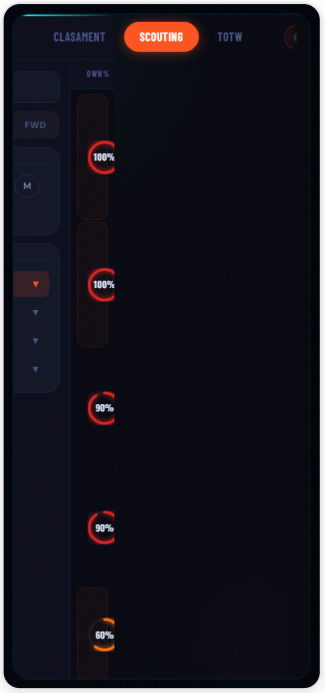
05 Responsive Scouting Layout

Progressive Disclosure + Desktop Data Table

DESKTOP — CURRENT STATE



MOBILE — CURRENT STATE



PROBLEM

One Layout Scaled Across All Screen Sizes

- Mobile: Every card shows ring + name + team + position + MD pts + goals + assists + total points simultaneously. Cards are 60px tall. Only ~8–10 players visible without scrolling — a critical bottleneck when scanning 40+ players.
- Filter controls (position segment + manager chips + sort buttons) stack in 3 rows, consuming ~100px before any player data appears — 12% of the screen wasted on controls.
- Desktop: The 7-column grid was designed for 820px but stretches across 1280px+ screens. Columns have no headers — users cannot identify which column shows goals vs assists without memorising the layout.
- The manager ownership stat (which of your league's managers owns this player) is invisible on desktop despite being the most strategically valuable fantasy data point — captaincy differentials, transfer targets, price rises.

APPLE PRINCIPLE

Progressive Disclosure

Apple shows users only what they need when they need it. iPhone Contacts shows name + photo in list view; tap for details. The App Store shows title + rating; tap for full notes. This reduces overwhelm while keeping all data accessible — the more you see at once, the less you actually absorb.

RECOMMENDATION

- **Mobile — Progressive Disclosure:** Default collapsed row shows ring + name + total points only (44px height = 36% slimmer). A chevron › expands to reveal goals, assists, MD pts inline below the name. *Result: 47% more players visible without scrolling.*

- **Mobile — Unified Filter Bar:** Replace 3 stacked filter rows with a single-line 44px bar: a 'Filters' pill (opens a bottom sheet with all options) + the active sort chip. 100px of filter space → 44px. More players, less chrome.
- **Desktop — Sortable Data Table:** Redesign as a macOS Numbers-style table with explicit column headers: Player · Pos · MD Pts ▼ · Goals · Assists · Total · Owned By. Headers are clickable with sort direction arrows. Data-dense, scannable, professonal.
- **Desktop — Column specification:** Player column `flex: 1` (generous name + team space). Stat columns fixed 72px, right-aligned. Alternating row shading at `rgba(255,255,255,0.025)`. Horizontal lines between rows.
- **Desktop — Manager Ownership column:** Show avatar stack of up to 3 manager initials who own this player, with a total count badge (e.g. '3/8 managers'). The single most valuable fantasy-manager data point — currently hidden despite existing in the API response.
- **Desktop — Filter bar:** Position segment + manager chips + sort all on one persistent top bar above the table. No stacking, no vertical scroll needed to find options.

EXPECTED IMPACT

Mobile: 47% more players visible per screen. Filter bar shrinks from 100px to 44px. Desktop: transforms from a stretched phone list into a proper analytics tool — the kind of interface that makes managers feel like they are making data-driven decisions. The Manager Ownership column alone is a meaningful feature unlock: the data already exists in the API but is currently invisible to users.

APPENDIX

Recommended Design Token System

TOKEN NAME	CURRENT VALUE	RECOMMENDED VALUE	USAGE
`--text-title-1`	—	28px / Barlow Condensed 800 / -0.03em	Page-level headings
`--text-title-2`	—	22px / Barlow Condensed 800 / -0.02em	Section headings, large numbers
`--text-headline`	—	17px / DM Sans 600	Card titles, modal headers
`--text-body`	—	15px / DM Sans 400	Default prose, descriptions
`--text-subheadline`	—	13px / DM Sans 500	Tab labels, secondary copy
`--text-footnote`	—	12px / DM Sans 400	Timestamps, tertiary info
`--text-caption`	—	11px / DM Sans 600 UPPERCASE +0.08em	Column headers, eyebrows
`--shadow-elevated`	0 2px 8px rgba(0,0,0,.15)	0 2px 8px rgba(0,0,0,.35), 0 8px 24px rgba(0,0,0,.25)	Cards
`--shadow-floating`	—	0 24px 64px rgba(0,0,0,.6), 0 8px 24px rgba(59,130,246,.12)	Modals, sheets
`--spring-press`	—	cubic-bezier(0.34, 1.56, 0.64, 1) 150ms	Button/card press animation
`--spring-modal`	—	cubic-bezier(0.32, 0.72, 0, 1) 380ms	Bottom sheet open animation
`--header-bg`	rgba(12,20,31,1)	rgba(12,20,31,.85) + backdrop-filter: blur(20px) saturate(1.8)	Header frosted glass material
`--focus-ring`	—	outline: 2px solid #FF5722; outline-offset: 2px	Keyboard :focus-visible ring
`--color-primary`	#FF5722 (--fire)	#FF5722 — rename --fire to --color-primary	Primary interactive color
`--tap-min`	24px (close btn)	44px minimum on all interactive elements	Apple HIG minimum tap target

IMPLEMENTATION PRIORITY

Quick wins (1–2 days): Token system + type scale consolidation, remove unused fonts, close button resize to 44px, backdrop tap-to-close, focus rings for keyboard nav.

Medium effort (3–5 days): Unified `.interactive` class, depth shadow system, frosted glass header, mobile filter bar consolidation, sliding tab indicator.

Larger effort (1–2 weeks): Swipe-to-dismiss bottom sheet with spring physics, desktop scouting redesign as sortable data table with manager ownership column.